



Cognitive Psychology (COGPSY)

Module 3: Memory: Encoding, Storage and Retrieval

Retrieval Cues and Improving Memory

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

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Retrieval Cues

Retrieval cues are signals that help you access stored information. Encoding specificity says recall works best when the cues available at recall are similar to those present during learning. Context, internal state, meaning links, and sensory cues can all support retrieval.

Why Memory Feels Poor

Often the memory is stored, but retrieval fails because the right cues are missing, the recall context differs from learning, or other information interferes. Proactive interference is when old learning blocks new. Retroactive interference is when new learning blocks old. Tip-of-the-tongue shows partial access without full recall.

How to Improve Retrieval

Use retrieval practice: test yourself instead of only rereading. Use elaborative encoding: link ideas to what you know. Use spaced repetition: review after one day, three days, and one week. Use mnemonics where helpful. Protect sleep and reduce extreme stress before exams.

Reflect: Which improvement method will you try this week: self-testing or spaced review?

Closing

Module 3 is the core memory module. Module 4 turns to thinking, language, reasoning, and judgment.